

Policy for Sustainable Agriculture in New South Wales



NSW Government



NSW Agriculture

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1. Foreword

Agriculture represents a diverse sector of the State's economy responsible for the production, processing, and marketing of food, fibre and ornamental products for domestic and export markets.

The success of the agricultural sector in New South Wales depends upon a range of structural and environmental factors including:

- the effective integration of production, transport, processing, marketing and service industries
- the skills of its managers and workforce
- the productive capacity of the natural resource base.

Agriculture's dependence upon seasonal weather conditions and world markets contributes significantly to the industry's fluctuating fortunes. Over the past two decades, farming and associated industries have suffered declining terms of trade to an extent where many agricultural businesses are no longer viable. This situation has often led to short term decision making for survival rather than strategic decision making for long term sustainability, despite widespread recognition of the need to address the causes of natural resource degradation in agricultural environments. A sustainable rural economy and healthy environment go hand in hand. The rural sector depends upon the physical environment for its well being, yet some agricultural activities have led to degradation of the natural resource base, which presents a significant challenge to the community as a whole. The NSW Government recognises this challenge and is working to ensure a sustainable future for agriculture in New South Wales.

The *Policy for Sustainable Agriculture in New South Wales* forms part of the process of incorporating principles and objectives of ecologically sustainable development into the ethos of agricultural industries in this State. It also aims to facilitate a change in agricultural production in New South Wales towards ecologically and economically sustainable practices and farming systems.

The Government will rely upon its agencies, farmers, industry groups, local authorities and environmental interest groups to implement the strategies presented in the Policy. Progress in implementing the Policy's objectives and ongoing review of the Policy's effectiveness will be monitored by the NSW Sustainable Agriculture Review Group, which will report to me.

The Policy recognises the shared goals of government, farmers and conservationists and the need for all stakeholders to work together to achieve a sustainable agricultural sector in New South Wales.



Bob Carr MP
Premier
of New South Wales

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2. Purpose of the Policy

The purpose of this Policy is to facilitate a coordinated approach to achieving an ecologically and economically sustainable agricultural sector in New South Wales. The Policy provides an agreed goal for sustainable agriculture in New South Wales, common objectives, and strategies that should guide a wide range of stakeholders towards this goal. It also provides a framework within which individual agencies and interest groups can develop specific position statements and action plans.

3. The goal for sustainable agriculture in New South Wales

Agricultural industries that contribute positively to the State's productivity and economy, protect the State's biological and physical resource base, and support the State's rural people and communities.

4. Sustainable agriculture

Agriculture, as with all human activity, must operate within the capacity of available resources to better secure the sector's long-term viability.

To be sustainable, agriculture must:

- respond to consumer needs for food and fibre products that are healthy and of high quality
- take full account of the costs of production, including environmental costs, and ensure its pricing reflects these costs
- protect and restore the natural resource base on which agriculture depends
- prevent adverse on-site and off-site impacts on the environment and any other sector of the community
- be flexible in order to accommodate regional differences and changing economic, environmental and social circumstances such as drought or terms of trade
- be financially viable.

Agriculture's positive economic and social contribution to the State relies on the establishment and maintenance of agricultural management systems that are economically viable both now and in the future, and take into account the environmental and social impacts of production upon present and future generations.

These features of sustainable agriculture should be considered as a package, and no single feature should predominate over the others.



High quality products meet consumer demands for healthy food and help NSW farmers to compete in the market place.

5. Background

5.1 The agricultural sector in New South Wales

Agriculture represents a diverse sector of the State's economy that includes the production, processing and marketing of food, fibre and ornamental products.

The sector has played a key role in the development of New South Wales and contributed to the character, culture and heritage value of our rural landscape. Seventy-five percent of the State's land resources and extracted water are used by agriculture to produce more than \$6 billion worth of high quality products, which account for 30 percent of the total national agricultural output each year.

As major users of natural resources in the State, agricultural industries and individual landholders have a significant role to play in managing the State's valuable resources. It is recognised that the development of successful, sustainable agricultural enterprises may require significant change, or adjustment, from existing practices.



5.2 Managing the environmental impacts of agriculture

It is increasingly evident that the benefits of agriculture we enjoy today have come at some cost to the community. The limitations of the Australian environment for agriculture have not always been fully understood; many agricultural practices, although used in good faith, have proved in hindsight to be inappropriate for the Australian landscape.

The current estimate of lost agricultural production due to the degradation of natural resources is \$700m a year. Agricultural industry stakeholders are committed to reducing that figure. Unfortunately, resource pricing and the market for agricultural products do not adequately reflect environmental costs.

Farmers in New South Wales are responding to the problems of land degradation in an effort to raise their productive capacity and secure their future in agriculture.

For example, during the last five years there has been a significant increase in the adoption of:

- reduced cultivation strategies
- stubble retention
- rotation of pastures with cropping
- more strategic control of pest animals and weeds
- improved effluent management systems from feedlots and piggeries.



Production, processing and marketing of agricultural products contributes to the agricultural sector that provides employment and economic support for rural communities.



Suitable enterprises and production methods are chosen and adapted to suit the climate, soils and other landscape features across the State.

Farmers are also active members of Landcare and Catchment Management Committees, and have improved their practices to reverse dryland salinity through the strategic planting of trees and deep rooted perennial pastures.

The NSW Government has also responded to problems associated with environmental degradation through:

- research and promotion to encourage conservation farming practices
- assistance for better natural resource management
- enhancement of environmental education
- development of coordinated natural resource policies, strategies and legislation
- whole-of-government reforms to the management of water, native vegetation and threatened species.

5.3 Community values

The community places a high value on the State's natural resources and expects these resources to be managed in an ecologically sustainable manner. The finite nature of New South Wales's natural resources that support agricultural production, demands a cooperative effort involving industry, landholders, all levels of government and the community in general.

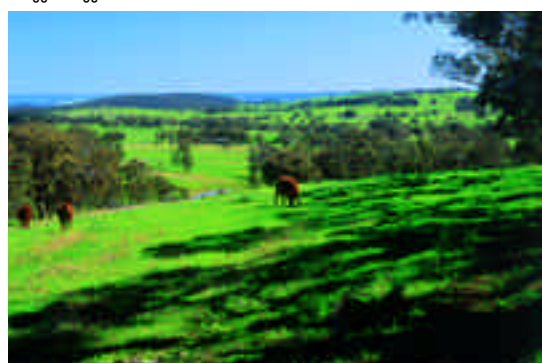
Canola cropping in the Central West.



Beef cattle grazing on the tablelands.



New crops and production methods trialed by NSW Agriculture researchers near Wagga Wagga.



Land management for sustainable agriculture protects natural resources while providing for productivity.

6. Policy Context

International, National and State policies and strategies provide a broad policy context within which the *Policy for Sustainable Agriculture in New South Wales* operates.

6.1 International

At the international level; the United Nations Environment Program, in conjunction with the World Conservation Union, has produced a World Conservation Strategy (now published as *Caring for the earth: a strategy for sustainable living*).

Australia has adopted this international Strategy through the preparation of a National Conservation Strategy. Australia is also a signatory to Agenda 21, an international action plan for implementing ecologically sustainable development. This plan was adopted at the *United Nation's Conference on the Environment and Development* held in Brazil in 1992. Through the adoption of these strategies, Australia has expressed a commitment to the international goal of sustainable development.



This agricultural landscape was transformed over eight years by tree planting, and improved farm design and land management practices.

6.2 National

Nationally, the following policy frameworks for Federal and State action have been endorsed by the Council of Australian Governments (COAG):

- National Conservation Strategy, which reflects international agreements
- National Agreement on Water Policy, which provides a strategic framework for reforms in areas such as water pricing, institutional structure, and allocation
- National Strategy for the Conservation of Australia's Biological Diversity
- National Greenhouse Response Strategy
- National Forest Policy.

The Intergovernmental Agreement on the Environment provides a National framework for achieving a cooperative and consistent approach to the environment and development, and defines the respective roles of Commonwealth, State and local governments.

The National Strategy for Ecologically Sustainable Development (ESD) is the broadest ranging National strategy. The ESD goal is: 'development that improves the total quality of life, both now and in the future, in a way that maintains the ecological processes on which life depends'.

It aims to enhance individual and community well-being and welfare by following a path of economic development that:

- safeguards the welfare of future generations
- provides for equity within and between generations
- protects biodiversity
- maintains essential ecological processes and life support systems.

(National Strategy for Ecologically Sustainable Development, December 1992).

6.3 State

At the State level, the principles of ESD have been included in the corporate plans of NSW Government agencies, as well as State legislation and policies developed over the past five years. The *Policy for Sustainable Agriculture in New South Wales* complements a broad range of State Government initiatives aimed at improving long-term productivity while protecting the environment, and supporting rural and regional communities in New South Wales. These initiatives include:

- partnership programs between the community and government such as Total Catchment Management, land and water management planning, Landcare and West 2000
- the requirement that rural community impact statements be prepared before making Cabinet decisions that may impact on rural communities
- State natural resource policies such as *The NSW State Rivers and Estuaries Policy*, *The NSW Wetlands Management Policy* and the draft *NSW Biodiversity Strategy*
- the State vegetation reform initiative, which focuses on the management and conservation of native vegetation through regional planning and clearing controls
- the State water reform package which aims to improve the sustainability of New South Wales rivers through the establishment by community groups of river and ground water management plans, changes to licencing arrangements and incentives for the efficient use of irrigation water
- the acid soil action program to correct problems of soil acidity in cropping, irrigation, horticultural and coastal areas
- the Healthy Rivers Commission assessment process which examines, in consultation with the community, problems and possible solutions for individual catchments.

7. Key issues, objectives and strategies

The complex and diverse nature of the agricultural sector needs to be taken into account when developing strategies to achieve sustainable agricultural practices. A broad range of issues needs to be considered within the following key areas:

- agricultural production
- land management
- water use and quality
- nature conservation on farms
- rural communities
- integrated management.

Each area is important in its own right. However, for sustainable agriculture to be achieved, the challenges presented within these areas must be addressed in a coordinated way. For each of these areas, this Policy briefly describes the key issues that need to be addressed, states an agreed objective, and then presents a range of strategies to be adopted by stakeholders in order to meet these objectives.

7.1 Agricultural production

Issue

Positive action by farmers to protect, restore and enhance the natural resource base and the broader environment largely depends on profitable

agricultural production. The development and adoption of best management practices, incentives, guidelines and training in farm business and risk management are necessary to enhance farm profitability and promote the adoption of agricultural practices that are both sustainable and productive. This includes the care of animals and plants in a diverse and healthy farming system.

Alternative farming systems are being examined and adopted in response to consumer demand for organically grown food. Market demand for 'clean food' is increasing both in Australia and overseas and presents a strong incentive for the use of organic farming practices. The establishment of markets for organic produce will help this industry to grow. Techniques trialed successfully on organic farms can then be transferred to conventional farms.

Effective management of pests and weeds is critical to agricultural productivity. Agricultural activities in New South Wales are threatened by key vertebrate pests including rabbits, feral pigs, foxes and wild dogs. Weeds may lower the productive capacity of land, threaten or displace native species, harbour feral animals, and affect human and animal health. Pest and weed control are therefore crucial to sustainable agriculture. However, concern remains that chemicals may be over used and, particularly in the case of pesticides, may be losing

Quality control in the processing and production of agricultural products ensures they meet market standards.



Pests are monitored regularly in apple orchards and other agricultural enterprises to allow timely and effective control.



Gherkins are graded and checked to ensure top quality in the final product.

their effectiveness. Other concerns include the potential of chemical products to alter predator-prey relationships, increase overall levels of environmental toxicity and affect human health. Biological control and integrated pest management strategies are being developed and implemented. With careful use of fertilisers, productivity will be enhanced, while residues in products and in the environment generally, are minimised.

Adoption of ISO14000 environmental management systems will improve on-farm production systems. Failure to implement agricultural systems that acknowledge resource constraints and enhance productive opportunities within the ecosystem will diminish agriculture's positive economic and social contribution to the State.

Objective:

Profitable agricultural industries producing high quality agricultural products in an ecologically sustainable manner that meets consumer needs, and based on a better understanding of the relationship between product prices and production costs, including environmental costs.

Strategies

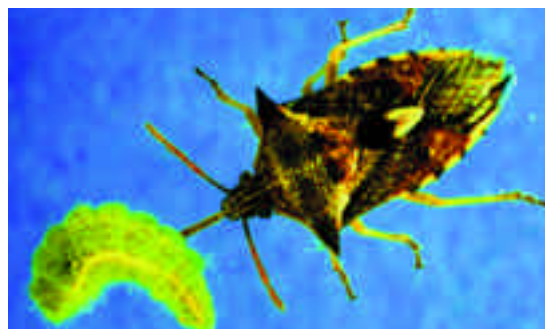
- Develop and adopt best management practices for agricultural industries in line with ESD principles.
- Facilitate industry adoption of environmental management systems and other quality assurance processes to meet community demands and provide market advantage.
- Promote training in and adoption of property management planning, including business and risk management.
- Develop and adopt best practices for animal welfare on farms, in research and in transport and marketing sectors.
- Develop and adopt alternative farming systems that allow adaptation to suit the variable soil and climate conditions of New South Wales.



Alternative crops and practices are compared on a small scale before testing with larger demonstrations under typical farming conditions.



The use of protective clothing is promoted to reduce the risks of pesticides to the health of farmers and their employees.



Beneficial insects such as this shield bug can be used as an alternative to pesticides to kill caterpillars and other pests. Research is identifying suitable insects and methods of agricultural management that encourage their survival.

- Enhance (with appropriate safeguards) the diversity of genotypes used in agricultural systems to provide increased security and quality of production.
- Explore and develop new domestic and export market opportunities for agricultural products from New South Wales (including organically grown products).

- Produce agricultural products that satisfy market needs and meet industry and trade standards. Where appropriate, inform the markets and adjust the standards to avoid unsustainable practices.
- Develop and adopt food production, processing and marketing strategies that improve human health.
- Define and measure quantifiable indicators of the state of the agricultural and related environment, to allow better decision making (both on-farm and regionally).
- Promote the long-term economic, environmental and social benefits of sustainable agriculture to farmers and the general community.
- Better inform rural communities of the role and appropriate use of agricultural and veterinary chemicals and biological pest control in sustainable agriculture.
- Reduce the reliance of industry on pesticides.
- Reduce the risks caused by pesticides to the environment and to human health.
- Promote community awareness of the relationships between product prices and production costs.

7.2 Land management

Issue

Land is crucial to agriculture. Unfortunately, past agricultural activities and policies, combined with the character of the State's landscape have had, in some cases, adverse impacts on the quality of the land resource.

This has been especially evident in:

- loss of native vegetation
- rising groundwater
- erosion
- dryland salinity
- soil acidification.

Land available for agriculture is limited and attracts competition for other uses. As some current land use practices have the potential to compound existing problems in the long-term, land should be managed to meet both present and future needs. This includes management of soil and vegetation, the control of pests and weeds, and management of organic wastes.

Sustainable farming systems replace soil nutrients harvested as pasture and crop products, with a view to long term on- and off-farm nutrient balance. The low rate of topsoil formation, which is a feature common to Australia, together with the basic importance of soil in producing agricultural wealth, makes it essential for soil to be regarded as a non-renewable resource. Effective soil management is needed to minimise and reverse significant soil structural degradation, salinity and acidity problems which exist in New South Wales.

Native vegetation, together with tree planting, can generate benefits to agriculture including protection of agricultural land from soil erosion and salinity. Windbreaks can increase the productivity of crops, pastures and livestock; shade trees can reduce heat stress and increase livestock productivity. Plans to preserve remnant native vegetation and to plant trees are therefore an important part of land management.

Despite their value to agricultural productivity, agricultural and veterinary chemicals can leave residues in both agricultural products and the environment. Fertilisers do not usually present a hazard if managed properly but they can pollute the environment. Management of these factors is also crucial to the issue of water use and quality, and to prevent problems such as eutrophication and oxygen depletion in water. Farmers, government and the community need to work together to manage existing residues in the environment.

Currently, many organic waste products are disposed of into the general environment after varying levels of treatment, or stored in land fill at significant financial and environmental cost. The nutrients, organic matter and water content in many waste

products could be used for agricultural production rather than creating pollution. However, strict environmental assessment and controls are necessary to ensure that the application of organic wastes to agricultural land matches the capacity of the agricultural systems to utilise or immobilise them.

Objective:

Agricultural land protected and managed for sustainable agricultural use with agricultural activity contributing to its protection and enhancement.

Strategies

- Develop awareness of the need to minimise adverse off-site impacts of land management practices.
- Improve awareness and assessment of the causes, symptoms and impacts of soil degradation.
- Encourage the protection, and promote the value of native vegetation and biodiversity in agricultural land management.
- Develop and adopt management practices and farming systems that conserve and enhance the health of soil resources.

- Maintain effective barriers to the importation and spread of weeds and pest animals.
- Promote and adopt integrated weed, pest and disease management strategies and best management practices (e.g. improved application technology, plant and animal breeding and biological control agents) that reduce the risks arising from use of agricultural and veterinary chemicals, with special recognition of the needs of farmers of non-English speaking background.
- Use fertilisers to achieve maximum benefits in replacing nutrients used to produce agricultural products, with minimal adverse impact on the environment.
- Monitor agricultural and veterinary chemical residues in agricultural products and in the environment; use the results to improve management performance.
- Further develop and manage the agricultural use of organic wastes from urban, industrial and agricultural activities so that the components of waste are effectively used by plant growth or sustainably assimilated by the soil at the application site.



Colour test kits can be used to measure levels of phosphorus in soil, helping farmers to regulate the amount of fertiliser they apply. An understanding of soil characteristics is essential to develop and promote farm practices that overcome salinity, acidity, and soil structural problems.



Sowing crops directly into stubble with minimal soil disturbance protects the soil surface and conserves soil biological activity.

7.3 Water use and quality

Issue

Australia is the world's driest inhabited continent where fresh water is a limited resource. There are many competing demands for its use. Irrigated agriculture in New South Wales can account for up to 75 percent of the water drawn from rivers and groundwater. Irrigation has affected water quality and flow in our major river systems, local and regional water tables and catchment ecology.

River systems are of great importance to agriculture and other industries; they also have industrial, environmental, urban, social and cultural significance. The survival of our river systems depends not only on the quality and availability of water, but also on the integrity of the overall ecological system, its functions and processes. In particular, many land use and management practices have severely degraded the riverine environment and continue to do so. Water use and quality issues are closely linked to the land use and protection issues and strategies discussed previously.



Soil sampling provides information that helps farmers to schedule their next irrigation.

Wetlands contribute to improved water quality by recycling nutrients and by absorbing and breaking down pollutants. They provide highly productive seasonal grazing and opportunistic cropping based on natural flooding, contributing to enterprise diversity. Agriculture can contribute to maintaining wetlands by adopting production systems and practices that prevent over-drainage or pollution of wetlands.

Groundwater systems are also important to agriculture and rural communities as a source of water for irrigation, livestock, and household use. Extensive clearing of trees from the landscape has contributed to recharging groundwater systems in many areas, raising groundwater levels and bringing salts to the surface. Excessive irrigation has also raised water tables to an extent that has limited the potential for production in some areas.

Groundwater quality and supply, and water table levels need greater protection and management to achieve sustainable development. Groundwater is also being considered in environmental impact assessments of developments involving water storage, tree clearing and floodplain management.

The following strategies are being widely promoted to address this issue:

- major tree and perennial pasture planting programs
- reduced cultivation practices
- more efficient irrigation techniques.

Objective:

Agriculture as an efficient and productive user of water contributing to the achievement of water quality and environmental flow objectives.

Strategies

- Develop, promote and adopt agricultural management practices that contribute beneficially to the management of rivers and riverine ecosystems, estuaries, groundwater and wetlands associated with agriculture; in line with other New South Wales policies.



Farm advisers use electronic equipment to monitor the soil water content. These measurements are used to schedule irrigations more accurately, making more efficient use of water.

- Adopt efficient and effective water use practices (by irrigators, pastoralists, and other water users) that conserve and enhance the quality of the environment.
- Develop and implement land and water management plans in irrigated agricultural areas including adoption of best farming practice, irrigation system designs and decision support systems that overcome water degradation and provide for long-term irrigation community viability.
- Provide government incentive programs that improve the sustainable use of water by agriculture.
- Participate collaboratively in the development of New South Wales water reform policy by promoting and adopting river and ground water management plans.



Trees and pasture planted near rivers help to protect water quality by preventing soil erosion and filtering runoff water, as well as conserving native wildlife.

7.4 Nature conservation on farms

Issue

Australia's biodiversity (that is: different plants, animals and micro-organisms, the genetic information they contain and the ecosystems they form), is a significant National asset with recognised global significance. Conservation of native flora and fauna and maintenance of critical habitat and ecological processes are crucial to maintaining biodiversity. The maintenance of biodiversity has significant benefits for agriculture, science and medicine.

Agriculture both contributes to and benefits from the retention and management of native vegetation. Tree planting to link significant vegetation remnants can protect soil and water resources and provide shelter for livestock and crops. Provision of habitats for the natural predators of agricultural pests can reduce the use of agricultural pesticides and create opportunities to conserve native flora and fauna. The agricultural benefits of wetlands, which contribute to biological diversity by providing plant and wildlife habitats as well as animal breeding and nursery areas, have been identified in section 7.3.



Trees are planted in strategic positions as windbreaks and woodlots on farms to protect the soil, provide shade and shelter for livestock, and to encourage birdlife.

As a major user of land in New South Wales, agriculture has an important role to play in the off-reserve conservation of native flora and fauna. Nature conservation objectives therefore, need to be incorporated into property, bio-regional and catchment management planning and regional vegetation management plans.

Objective:

Agriculture making a beneficial contribution to the protection and management of the State's natural heritage and biodiversity.

Strategies

- Identify priorities for conservation on agricultural land.
- Adopt farming systems that conserve and enhance biodiversity.
- Adopt management plans that integrate nature conservation on-farm with agricultural production systems.
- Investigate and promote, using appropriate incentives, the agricultural and ecological benefits of conserving and supplementing remnant native vegetation.
- Recognise the integral role of trees, shrubs, perennial grasses and legumes in property and catchment management planning.
- Manage pest animals in ways that optimise agricultural and ecological benefits, and promote species conservation.
- Consider the establishment of sustainable farming of suitable native species.
- Ensure that the off-site effects of agriculture do not adversely affect areas set aside for nature conservation.

7.5 Rural communities

Issue

The relationship between the agricultural sector, and rural and regional communities is often one of interdependence. Agriculture provides the economic base of many rural and regional towns and contributes to the development of rural communities by creating jobs and economic wealth. At the same time, the agricultural sector often depends upon many services provided by rural and regional centres, such as:

- effective communication
- transport
- financial services
- networks for the supply of water and energy
- other agricultural inputs and services.

In addition, rural and regional towns provide a social focus for people involved in the surrounding agricultural industries, and are a source of goods and services that are essential to the maintenance of general community welfare. Coordinated planning and management of services in rural and regional New South Wales is therefore important not only to the long term prosperity of rural communities but also to the productivity of agricultural industries.

Agricultural lands may also include places of value to the community such as Aboriginal and non-Aboriginal sites of cultural importance, and natural heritage areas. These places are not only irreplaceable but contribute to a sense of regional identity, and may have value for activities such as tourism and education. Managing agricultural activities to avoid negative impacts on these areas will help to ensure that they survive for the future.

Objective:

Agriculture making a beneficial contribution to regional and State economies and contributing to the support of the State's rural people and communities.

Strategies

- Facilitate consultation among agricultural industries, indigenous stakeholders, government and the community on issues affecting rural people, families and communities.
- Improve the coordination and complementary nature of rural policies and services.
- Facilitate the structural adjustment of agricultural industries and rural communities to enhance the sustainability of agriculture, including the provision and effective use of rural adjustment assistance.
- Provide opportunities for agricultural processing facilities to be located in rural areas and to strengthen their associated support infrastructure.
- Include the full range of agricultural industries in regional development strategies.



Meat processing in country towns provides employment and a vital link between producers and processors in the one community. Producers and processors cooperate to adapt their management methods to meet the needs of consumers.

7.6 Integrated management

Issue

For agriculture to operate in an ecologically sustainable manner while meeting economic and social goals, mechanisms are needed to facilitate consultation and cooperative action between industry, government, local authorities and community groups.

Consultation and coordination among these groups will allow common interests to be met without duplication and wasted effort, and make best use of existing institutional arrangements and legal instruments which facilitate agricultural planning and assessment.

Agricultural activities are under threat at the rural-urban interface across the State because population growth and urban expansion can result in the loss of prime agricultural lands. Adequate planning processes are needed to ensure that the land best suited for agriculture is retained. Urban encroachment and community concern over dust, odour and noise are placing increasing pressures on

agricultural activities. State agencies, local government, the agricultural sector and the wider community need to understand these issues and manage them through appropriate planning strategies and agricultural practices.

Objective:

Agricultural industries, communities and governments working together to achieve positive economic, environmental and social outcomes.

Strategies

- Implement policies and provide information to encourage the adoption of sustainable agricultural practices.
- Ensure collaboration in the development, implementation and review of plans, policies and legislation relating to agriculture.
- Use Total Catchment Management and Landcare principles and plans to ensure that the off-site impacts of agriculture are considered and managed effectively.



Effective planning, for example providing buffer zones, can minimise the conflict that arises where agricultural land adjoins urban development.



Landcare and farm production groups put environmental policy into practice, and identify environmental issues in the field.

- Ensure the equitable and efficient allocation of land and other natural resources between agriculture and other sectors of the community.
- Ensure land use planning is undertaken, where appropriate, in association with agriculture to avoid conflict that may jeopardise agriculture's sustainability.
- Ensure enactment of environmental impact assessment procedures that result in the sustainable development of agriculture.
- Coordinate monitoring and reporting of the state of the agricultural and related environment, using measurable indicators that contribute to decision making.
- Develop and adopt agricultural activities and planning strategies that minimise impacts on community amenity from noise, dust and odour.
- Identify lands and farming methods best suited to specific agricultural industries and retain production options for those lands in the future.



Property management planning integrates the production, environmental and personal goals of farmers with the physical attributes of the property.

- Develop and adopt appropriate planning mechanisms to avoid future conflict over land use (e.g. competing demands for land for agricultural, residential and recreational uses).
- Ensure efficient allocation and use of resources provided by the Commonwealth and State governments for agricultural resource management and improvement.

8. Policy coordination and review

Responsibility for implementing the Policy for Sustainable Agriculture in New South Wales lies principally with:

- New South Wales Government agencies
- farmers
- local authorities
- environmental interest groups.

The objectives and strategies outlined in the *Policy for Sustainable Agriculture in New South Wales* will be used both to guide stakeholders in the agricultural sector in decision-making with respect to agricultural activities, and to facilitate a coordinated approach to achieving an ecologically and economically sustainable agricultural sector in New South Wales.

Progress by stakeholders in implementing the strategies in the Policy will be monitored by a NSW Sustainable Agriculture Review Group which will

continue the representation of organisations involved in preparation of this policy, and which will be convened by the Minister for Agriculture.

The Review Group will meet annually, following the announcement of the Policy. The Group will prepare a report to the Premier on the implementation of the Policy's strategies by key agencies and stakeholders, and progress in meeting the Policy's objectives.

An important aspect of the Review Group's role will be to facilitate coordination and the exchange of information among agencies, and to review the Policy's effectiveness in promoting sustainable agricultural practices in New South Wales.



Canola, cereal crops and pasture for grazing sheep are used in rotation on this farm to maintain a healthy, productive agricultural environment. Careful management of the rural landscape, by using diverse enterprises and retaining remnant vegetation, is an essential component of sustainable agriculture.